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Beyond
Screens

A digital detox initiative

Delayed Gratification & Internet Addiction: Why Waiting Feels So Hard

What is Delayed Gratification?

Delayed gratification means choosing to wait for a bigger or better reward instead of taking something smaller right now. For example, you really want to watch YouTube now, but you know if you finish your work first, you'll feel less stressed and enjoy your break more.

That's delayed gratification, you wait now, to feel better later!

Why Screens Make Waiting Hard?

Screens make waiting hard because they constantly give us quick rewards like likes, messages, or videos that trigger dopamine, the brain's "feel-good" chemical. Over time, this trains our brain to expect instant satisfaction, making slow or boring tasks (like studying or waiting) feel frustrating. As a result, we get impatient more easily, struggle to focus, and are more likely to choose short-term fun over long-term goals. This habit of chasing quick rewards weakens our ability to wait, focus, or stick with things that take time.

This trains your brain to expect quick dopamine hits which makes waiting, focusing, or doing "boring" tasks harder.

Quick Reflection

Which of these tempt you when you're trying to focus? (Check all that apply)

- ☐ Checking messages
- ☐ Opening Instagram or Snapchat
- ☐ Watching "just one more" video
- ☐ Playing a quick game
- ☐ Refreshing for new content

What usually happens when you give in to those temptations?

Can you think of a time you waited and it paid off? What was the reward?

The Marshmallow Test

Imagine this; You're given two choices:

- Take 1 candy right now.
- Wait 15 minutes and get 2 candies.

What would you choose and why?

Now try and apply that to your daily habits:

- Would you rather scroll now or feel proud for finishing your work first?
- Would you rather stay up late watching videos or get a full night's sleep?

Train Your Brain to Wait

Try these small acts of delayed gratification this week:

- Leave your phone in another room while studying
- Wait 10 minutes before opening an app (set a timer)
- Finish a task before checking messages
- Make a list of rewards you can earn by waiting (e.g., free time, treats, music break)

This week, I will challenge myself to wait instead of giving in to: _____.

And I'll reward myself with: _____.